from the Philippines and gets it delivered to her doorstep without her having to step out of her fuzzy slippers. If you think this was possible before 'e-commerce' came into our lives – think again!

So what is this magical term e-commerce that lets us buy things from all around the world simply through the magical portal called the Internet? How did it come into being and importantly how big is it really today in India?

Put simply, e-commerce is the term used for buying and selling goods and services through the Internet. The first form of e-commerce started in the 1970s when it was used by businesses to send commercial documents such as purchase orders or invoices electronically. However, it wasn't until 1990 when the World Wide Web was introduced and it took another four years until advances such as online banking and the opening of an online pizza shop by Pizza Hut in USA took place. During this time (1994) Netscape introduced secure encryption of data transferred online which gave birth to Amazon in 1995 and E-bay in 1996 in the United States.

However, in India, e-commerce did not really pick up steam until much later. In fact, in India online shopping only gained in popularity post the dot com bubble bust in 2000. In the past 12 years, online shopping within India has developed and evolved to a great extent. E-commerce in India has gone from having a few online buyers that were hesitant to buy even small ticket items despite having credit cards, to a thriving community of customers that are comfortable buying a wide range of items online and do so without owning any form of credit at all.

Initial problems with e-commerce

In the early days of e-commerce, there were significant structural and